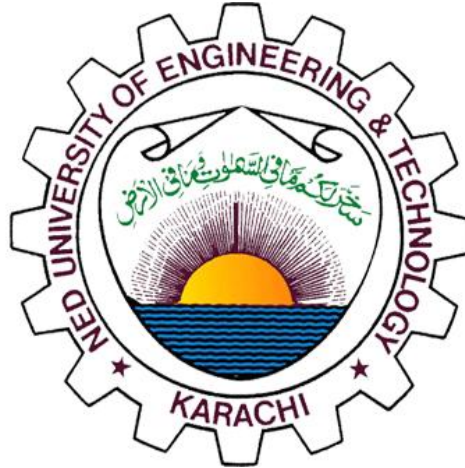


NED UNIVERSITY OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY

Department of Computer Science and Information Technology



Pakistan Studies (ES-105)

TOPIC: **Decline of Muslims in South Asia**

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Table of Contents

Contents	Page no	
Introduction	3-6	Shaheera Raza (CT-25252)
Political Fragmentation and Weak Muslim Leadership	7-10	Ayisha Nayyer Khan (CT-25262)
British Colonialism and Loss of Muslim's Political Power	11-14	Marium Tariq (CT-25254)
Educational, Economic and Social Decline	15-18	Aiman Yousuf (CT-25255)
Conclusion	19-21	Hunza Zulfiqar (CT-25256)

1. Introduction

1.1. The War of Independence (1857): The First Collective Anti-Colonial Uprising

The uprising of 1857 occupies a central place in the history of the subcontinent as the first large-scale and organized challenge to British colonial authority. It was not a sudden military disturbance, nor can it be reduced to the greased cartridge incident alone. Rather, historians emphasize that it was the outcome of decades of accumulated political humiliation, economic exploitation, cultural disruption, and military grievances that affected different classes of Indian society. Soldiers, peasants, artisans, dispossessed rulers, and religious groups despite their differences found a shared cause in resisting foreign domination. This convergence of diverse grievances transformed scattered resentment into a widespread revolt



¹Dalrymple, William. *The Last Mughal*. Bloomsbury, 2006

1.2. Political Displacement and the Systematic Dismantling of Indigenous Rule

One of the deepest causes of the uprising was the steady destruction of indigenous political authority. Through policies such as the Doctrine of Lapse and subsidiary alliances, the British East India Company annexed numerous states and reduced local rulers to powerless pensioners. Courts, administrative systems, and traditional centers of authority were replaced by British officials unfamiliar with local customs and governance traditions.

R.C. Majumdar argues that this political displacement created widespread dissatisfaction among ruling elites and their dependents, who had lost both status and livelihood. William Dalrymple further notes that by the mid-nineteenth century, the Mughal Emperor had been reduced to a symbolic figure under British surveillance, reflecting the complete erosion of native sovereignty. This systematic dismantling of political structures convinced many that British rule was not temporary but intended to permanently replace indigenous authority.

1.3. Educational Changes and Cultural Dislocation

The introduction of Western education and the replacement of Persian with English as the official language had far reaching social consequences. Communities that had traditionally dominated administrative and intellectual life suddenly found themselves excluded from government employment and social influence.

Tariq Rahman highlights how contemporary Urdu writings of the period reflect a sense of cultural loss and humiliation, particularly among Muslims who had previously held positions of authority. The decline of traditional educational institutions and the rise of English education created a class divide and a deep sense

of insecurity among those left behind. This cultural dislocation was not merely educational change; it was perceived as an attack on identity and heritage

1.4. Economic Exploitation and the Collapse of Local Livelihoods

British economic policies severely disrupted the traditional economic structure of the subcontinent. Heavy land revenue systems burdened peasants, while the destruction of handicraft industries eliminated the livelihood of artisans. India was turned into a supplier of raw materials and a market for British manufactured goods.

Eric Stokes, in his study of peasant participation in the revolt, argues that rural distress played a crucial role in mobilizing support against British authority. Sharif al-Mujahid similarly emphasizes that economic exploitation created a shared suffering among civilians and soldiers alike. Poverty, unemployment, and the steady drain of wealth to Britain made British rule increasingly unpopular among the masses.

1.5. Social and Religious Anxiety under Colonial Interference

British missionary activities and social reforms created fears that indigenous religious and social traditions were under threat. Although some reforms were presented as progressive, they were often viewed with suspicion by local communities.

Majumdar explains that rumors and perceptions of religious interference spread quickly among both Hindus and Muslims, creating a sense that the British intended to reshape society according to foreign values. This shared anxiety helped unite otherwise divided communities in resistance to colonial policies.

1.6. Military Grievances and the Immediate Spark

Indian soldiers in the British army faced racial discrimination, low pay, and limited opportunities for promotion. Their religious sensitivities were frequently ignored. The introduction of the Enfield rifle cartridges rumored to be greased with cow and pig fat became the immediate cause of revolt.

Dalrymple notes that while the cartridge issue triggered the uprising, it succeeded only because it fell upon soldiers already angered by long-standing grievances. Thus, the military factor acted as a spark to ignite a much larger store of accumulated discontent.

1.7. 1857 as a Turning Point in Historical Consciousness

Later historians argue that 1857 should not be dismissed as a mere mutiny. Instead, it represented the first collective expression of anti-colonial resistance in the subcontinent. Although the revolt failed militarily, it exposed weaknesses in British rule and profoundly shaped future resistance movements.

Dalrymple and Rahman both emphasize that the memory of 1857 survived in literature, folklore, and political thought, influencing later struggles for independence. It marked a psychological turning point where colonial authority was openly challenged on a massive scale.²

² Dalrymple, William. *The Last Mughal*. Bloomsbury, 2006.

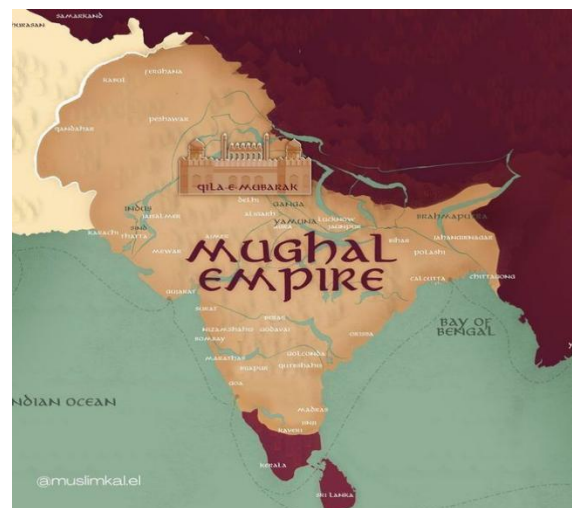
Rahman, Tariq. "The Events of 1857 in Contemporary Urdu Writings." *Pakistan Perspectives*.

2. Political fragmentation and weak Muslim leadership:

2.1. Abstract:

The history of the Indian subcontinent before British colonial rule (i.e., before roughly the mid-18th century) is marked by **political fragmentation, shifting centers of power, and competing Muslim polities.**

Rather than a unified or consistently centralized Muslim leadership, the region saw a **patchwork of dynasties, competing rulers, and overlapping authorities** that both reflected and reinforced the broader socio-political complexity of South Asia. This fragmentation had long-term consequences for the capacity of Muslim rulers to sustain unified control or present coherent political leadership across the subcontinent.



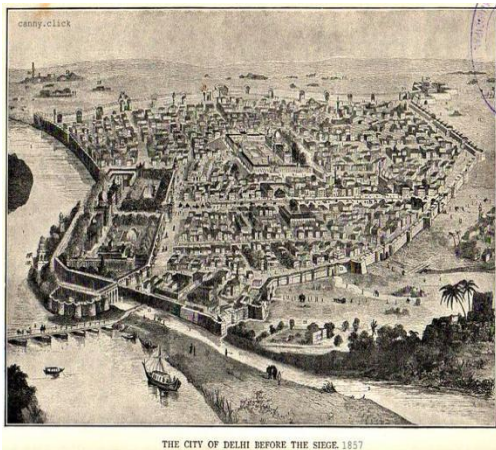
2.2. FACTORS:

1. Early Muslim Conquests and Emergence of Multiple Polities:

The **Delhi Sultanate (1206–1526)** is a key example of early Muslim political authority in northern India, but even here central control was uneven and contested. The Sultanate was not a monolithic state but consisted of **several dynastic houses** — the Mamluks, Khaljis, Tughlaqs, Sayyids, and Lodis — each contesting power amidst internal factionalism and regional resistance. Internal challenges such as administrative

inefficiencies, court intrigues, and revolts often undermined centralized authority, especially in the later years of Khalji and Tughlaq rule.³

Furthermore, as the Sultanate declined, it fractured into a **network of independent and semi-autonomous Muslim sultanates** across the subcontinent. Regions such as Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, and the Deccan developed their own courts and rulers,



frequently in conflict with one another or with the remnants of the Delhi center. The **Bahmani Sultanate in the Deccan**, for example, emerged in the early 14th century and later split into five successor states (Bijapur, Golconda, Ahmednagar, Bidar, and Berar).⁴ Such political decentralization shows how the decline of centralized authority often led to **regional powers asserting autonomy**, rather than any cohesive or unified

Muslim political structure emerging.

2. Structural Causes of Fragmentation:

In fragmentation Geography and demographics played a significant role: the Indian subcontinent's vast size, varied terrain, and diverse populations limited the ability of any single ruler or dynasty to wield authority uniformly across distant provinces. The administrative systems developed by early Muslim rulers were often patrimonial and heavily reliant on local elites, reducing the state's ability to enforce uniform governance.⁵

Moreover, the **heterogeneity of Muslim leadership itself** contributed to political fragmentation. Muslim rulers came from diverse ethnic and cultural backgrounds (Turkish, Afghan, Persian, and local converts), each bringing different political technologies and loyalties. The Sultanate's reliance on **military slaves (Mamluks)**

³ Marwat, Safi, Latif, Shafaeen: *Rise and Fall of Delhi Sultanate in India (1206-1526): An Analysis*

⁴ Majumdar, R.C (1960): [*History and Culture of the Indian People, Volume 06, The Delhi Sultanate*](#)

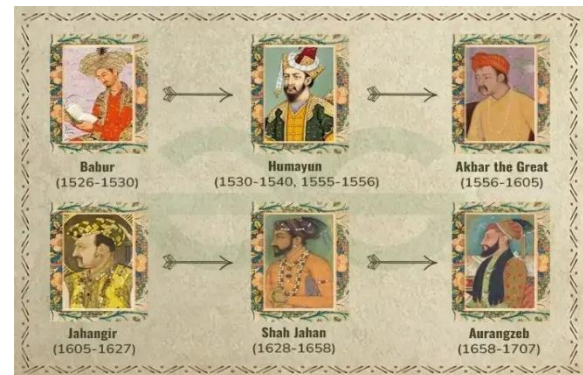
⁵ Mohamed nasr: *Muslim Rule In Medieval India Power And Religion In The Delhi Sultanate*

and decentralized patronage networks meant that central authority was constantly negotiated with powerful subordinate elites, whose loyalties were unstable.

In the Deccan and South India, Muslim polities such as the **Bahmani and later Deccan Sultanates** further illustrate how competing centers of Muslim authority emerged, often with uneven administrative cohesion. These states frequently engaged in warfare with each other as well as with powerful non-Muslim states like the Vijayanagara Empire, underscoring the **overlapping and contested political landscape**.⁶

3. The Transition towards Mughal Centralization:

Mughal centralization, which initially strengthened Muslim rule in the subcontinent, ultimately **contributed to its decline** due to structural weaknesses embedded within the **imperial system**. The Mughal state revolved heavily around the personal authority of the emperor, functioning as a **patrimonial-bureaucratic system**. While strong rulers like **Akbar** maintained stability, weak successors after **Aurangzeb** lacked the authority to control ambitious nobles and provincial governors. The absence of a fixed law of succession further intensified instability through frequent and destructive wars of succession.⁷



The **mansabdari and jagirdari** systems, central pillars of Mughal administration, also became sources of crisis. The system depended on continuous territorial expansion to supply revenue assignments. When expansion slowed in the late 17th century, there were insufficient jagirs to satisfy the growing nobility. This “**jagirdari crisis**” led to elite competition, corruption, and weakening central authority.⁸ Moreover, Mughal

⁶ Pushkar Sohooni: *The Architecture of a Deccan Sultanate*

⁷ Richards: *The Mughal Empire*

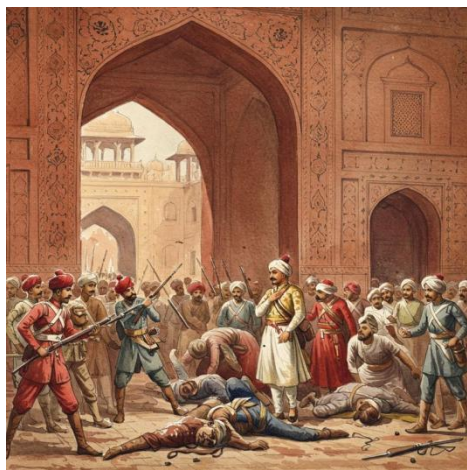
⁸ Irfan Habib: *The Agrarian System of Mughal India*

centralization suppressed the development of strong, autonomous provincial institutions. While this prevented early rebellion, it meant that when the central authority weakened after 1707, governors in **Bengal, Awadh, and Hyderabad** quickly asserted independence. The empire fragmented rapidly because its unity had depended almost entirely on imperial control.⁹

Finally, heavy revenue extraction to sustain the centralized military and bureaucracy created agrarian strain and rural unrest, further **destabilizing the empire** (Habib). Thus, the same centralized system that once ensured imperial strength became a **structural liability**. When fiscal pressures, military overextension, and weak leadership combined in the early 18th century, **Mughal authority collapsed**, paving the way for regional powers and **eventually European dominance**.¹⁰

In this way, Mughal centralization did not merely **fail**, it actively shaped the conditions under which Muslim political rule in the **subcontinent declined**.

2.3. Conclusion



Before British colonialism, the Indian subcontinent's Muslim political history was characterized by **fragmentation rather than unified leadership**. Multiple Muslim polities Sultanates, regional kingdoms, and competing dynasties operated within a highly plural and contested environment. Structural factors like geography, administrative norms, elite factionalism, and cultural diversity inhibited the emergence of cohesive leadership, even as Muslim rulers shaped the region's political and cultural contours. **Understanding this pre-colonial fragmentation is crucial** for appreciating how the later arrival of colonial

⁹ Alam, Muzaffar & Subrahmanyam, Sanjay: *The Mughal State (1526–1750)*

¹⁰ Habib, Irfan: *The Agrarian System of Mughal India (1556–1707)*.

powers found a political landscape already accustomed to decentralized authority and complex, multi-layered leadership.

3. British Colonialism and the Loss of Muslim Political Power

The rise of British colonial rule in the Subcontinent was perhaps the most painful transformation in the history of the Muslim community. For nearly a thousand years, Muslims had been the architects of India's political, cultural, and judicial landscape. However, the arrival of the British East India Company initiated a systematic dismantling of this authority. This shift was not merely a change in the name of ruler; it was the total replacement of an indigenous civilization with



of
with

3.1. The Initial Military Setbacks: Plassey and Buxar

The process of losing political power began on the battlefield, where the British used a combination of superior technology and internal conspiracies to weaken Muslim states. The Battle of Plassey in 1757 was the first major blow.¹¹ The defeat of Nawab Siraj-ud-

¹¹ Metcalf, T. R. (1995). *Ideologies of the Raj*. Cambridge University Press

¹² Hunter, W. W. (1871). *The Indian Musalmans: Are They Bound in Conscience to Rebel Against the Queen?* Trübner & Co.

Daulah in Bengal—largely due to the betrayal of his own generals—gave the British control over the wealthiest province of India.

This was followed by the Battle of Buxar in 1764, which was even more significant. The combined forces of the Mughal Emperor and the Nawabs were defeated, forcing the emperor to grant the British the *Diwani* (the right to collect taxes). This marked a tragic shift: the Muslim rulers, who were once the providers of justice and security, were now stripped of their financial independence. The British moved from being simple merchants to being the true masters of the land.

3.2. The "Stroke of the Pen": Language and Judicial Shift

While battles were fought with swords, the most permanent damage to Muslim political power was done through administrative changes. For centuries, Persian had been the official language of the government, the law courts, and the elite. It was the medium through which the Muslims managed the state.

In 1835, the British passed the English Education Act, and by 1837, they officially replaced Persian with English and local vernaculars. For the Muslim community, this was a catastrophe. Suddenly:

- The entire Muslim educated class was rendered "illiterate" in the eyes of the new law.
- Muslims were excluded from government jobs, which had been their traditional source of income and influence.
- The judicial system was changed from Islamic Law to British Common Law, removing Muslim judges (Qazis) from their positions of power.¹³

¹³ Qureshi, I. H. (1962). *The Muslim Community of the Indo-Pakistan Subcontinent*. Columbia University Press.

3.3. 1857: The Final Eclipse of the Mughal Empire

The War of Independence in 1857 represents the final, tragic climax of the loss of Muslim power. Muslims across the Subcontinent saw this war as a holy struggle to reclaim their lost dignity and restore the sovereignty of the Mughal Throne. When the uprising failed, the British directed their heaviest anger toward the Muslims, whom they viewed as the



chief "conspirators." The treatment of the last Mughal Emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar, was a moment of profound sorrow for the community. He was tried in his own palace, humiliated, and exiled to Rangoon, where he eventually died in poverty. With his exile, the symbolic heart of Muslim political identity in India was stopped forever. The Red Fort, once a symbol of Mughal grandeur, became British barracks.¹⁴

3.4. Strategic Annexations and the Doctrine of Lapse

To ensure that no Muslim power could rise again, the British used various legal strategies to seize remaining territories. The "Doctrine of Lapse" was a primary tool, allowing the British to take over any state where the ruler died without a direct male heir.

The annexation of Oudh (Lucknow) in 1856 was particularly devastating. Oudh was the last great sanctuary of Muslim culture, literature, and political refinement. Its fall meant that the Muslim nobility lost their last remaining lands and titles. Thousands of families who had served the state for generations were suddenly left without a home or a livelihood, leading to a deep sense of psychological and political despair.¹⁵

¹⁴ Dalrymple, W. (2006). *The Last Mughal: The Fall of a Dynasty, Delhi, 1857*. Bloomsbury Publishing.

¹⁵ Hardy, P. (1972). *The Muslims of British India*. Cambridge University Press.

3.5. The Policy of "Divide and Rule"

As the British consolidated their power, they adopted the "Divide and Rule" strategy to prevent any future united front against them. Since the British had taken power *from* the Muslims, they naturally viewed the Muslim community with suspicion and distrust.¹⁶

They began to favor other communities in education and civil services to create a new class of loyalists. This intentional marginalization ensured that Muslims remained politically isolated. They were no longer the "Rulers"; they were now a "Minority" struggling to find their place in a system designed to keep them at the bottom. This policy sowed the seeds of communal tension that would define the politics of the Subcontinent for the next century.

"The British Empire in India was a giant with feet of clay; it survived not by its own strength, but by the carefully maintained divisions of those it ruled. They did not just divide to conquer; they divided to endure."

— Shashi Tharoor

¹⁶ Khan, Sir Syed Ahmed. (1858). *Asbab-e-Baghawat-e-Hindh (The Causes of the Indian Revolt)*

4.Educational, Economic and Social Decline of Muslims of South Asia

4.1. Introduction

The decline of Muslims in South Asia began with the weakening of the Mughal Empire in the eighteenth century and became more evident under British colonial rule. Political displacement resulted in educational stagnation, economic hardship, and social disorientation within the Muslim community. The loss of state patronage and administrative authority significantly altered the position Muslims had previously enjoyed in the subcontinent.¹⁷

4.2. Political Background and Fall of Muslim Rule

The gradual collapse of Mughal authority led to the erosion of Muslim political dominance in the subcontinent. By the eighteenth century, the empire had already been weakened by internal conflicts, regional uprisings, and economic instability. As Mughal control declined, regional powers and eventually the British East India Company filled the political vacuum. Under Mughal governance, Muslims had occupied key administrative, judicial, and military positions and enjoyed considerable cultural prestige. Political authority was closely connected with social status and economic security.

With the consolidation of British power, these long-standing structures were systematically dismantled. The introduction of new administrative systems replaced traditional offices and reduced the influence of Muslim elites. The decisive blow came after the War of 1857, which the British largely attributed to Muslim leadership because the rebellion was symbolically conducted in the name of the last Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar. Following the suppression of the revolt, the British adopted

¹⁷ I. H. Qureshi, *The Muslim Community of the Indo-Pakistan Subcontinent (610–1947)* (Karachi: Ma'arif Publishers, 1977).

policies that excluded many Muslims from positions of authority, confiscated properties, and curtailed their participation in governance.



Capture of Bahadur Shah Zafar and his sons by William Hodson at Humayun's Tomb

4.3. Educational Decline of Muslims in South Asia

One of the most critical dimensions of decline was educational backwardness. Persian had served as the official language of administration during Mughal rule, and Muslim elites were trained in traditional Islamic and Persian scholarship. However, in 1837, the British replaced Persian with English as the official language of administration.¹⁸ This change disadvantaged Muslims who were less inclined to adopt English education due to religious conservatism and distrust of colonial intentions. In contrast, Hindu communities adapted more rapidly to English education and secured employment in the expanding colonial bureaucracy.

Following 1857, British suspicion toward Muslims further limited their access to educational and administrative opportunities.¹⁹ Recognizing the urgency of reform, Sir Syed Ahmad Khan initiated the Aligarh Movement, advocating modern education and

¹⁸ Peter Hardy, *The Muslims of British India* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1972).

¹⁹ K. K. Aziz, *The Making of Pakistan*.

scientific learning. The establishment of the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College in 1875 marked a turning point in Muslim educational reform.²⁰

4.4. Economic Decline under British Rule

The economic decline of Muslims was closely connected to political displacement and colonial economic restructuring. The abolition of jagirs and stipends deprived many Muslim aristocratic families of their traditional sources of income. Additionally, British industrial policies severely affected indigenous industries, particularly textiles, where many Muslims were employed. The influx of machine-made British goods led to the collapse of local crafts and small-scale production.²¹

Urban centers such as Delhi and Lucknow, once flourishing hubs of Muslim culture and commerce, suffered economic deterioration after 1857 due to administrative restructuring and reduced patronage.²² These developments collectively contributed to widespread poverty and economic marginalization among Muslims.

4.5. Social and Cultural Decline



The loss of political authority and economic stability produced a profound social and psychological impact. Muslims experienced a decline in social prestige and a crisis of identity under foreign rule.²³ In response, various reform movements emerged. The Deoband Movement emphasized religious revival and preservation of Islamic scholarship, seeking to protect Muslim identity from colonial influence.²⁴ In

contrast, the Aligarh Movement promoted modern education and engagement with

²⁰ I. H. Qureshi, *The Muslim Community of the Indo-Pakistan Subcontinent*.

²¹ Peter Hardy, *The Muslims of British India*.

²² I. H. Qureshi, *The Muslim Community of the Indo-Pakistan Subcontinent*.

²³ Francis Robinson, *Separatism Among Indian Muslims* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1974).

²⁴ Barbara D. Metcalf, *Islamic Revival in British India: Deoband, 1860–1900* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1982).

Western knowledge systems. These differing approaches reflected internal debates within the Muslim community regarding adaptation and reform.

4.6. Reform and Revival Efforts

Despite the decline, the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries witnessed the gradual emergence of Muslim political consciousness. Intellectual debates concerning representation, identity, and community organization laid the foundation for future political mobilization.²⁵ Educational reform and social activism contributed to the eventual revival of Muslim political thought in British India.

4.7. Conclusion

The decline of Muslims in South Asia during British rule was multidimensional, encompassing political marginalization, educational backwardness, economic hardship, and social disorientation. However, reform movements such as Aligarh and Deoband played a crucial role in addressing these challenges. While the nineteenth century represented a period of decline, it also marked the beginning of intellectual and political regeneration within the Muslim community.

²⁵ Ayesha Jalal, *Self and Sovereignty: Individual and Community in South Asian Islam* (London: Routledge, 2000).

5. Conclusion:

As our presentation comes to an end, it becomes clear that the decline of Islam in South Asia did not happen because of one single event. Instead, it took place slowly over time due to many connected factors and changing circumstances. ^[26] ^[27]

We began by looking at the broader background, and then examined how political fragmentation and weak leadership played a major role. When strong centralized authority declined, unity weakened, and internal divisions made it difficult to respond to external challenges. This political instability made Muslim rule increasingly vulnerable. ^[2] ^[28]

We then talked about British colonialism and how it changed the whole power structure of the region. As Muslim political control came to an end and British rule took over, Muslims gradually lost their roles in administration, the military, and decision-making. With time, this loss of authority also affected their confidence and their position in society. ^[1] ^[3]



Another major reason was the decline in education, economy, and social conditions. When new systems of education and governance were introduced, many Muslims were not able to adjust to them quickly. Because of this, they started falling behind in job opportunities and financial stability, which slowly weakened their overall social position as well ^[3]^[2].

²⁶ Metcalf, Barbara D. & Metcalf, Thomas R. *A Concise History of Modern India*.

²⁷ Robinson, Francis. *Islam and Muslim History in South Asia*. Oxford University Press, 2000.

²⁸ Hardy, Peter. *The Muslims of British India*. Cambridge University Press, 1972.

When we look at all these factors together, we see that the decline was not sudden. It was a gradual transformation caused by political loss, reduced access to education, economic challenges, and changing social conditions. Each factor reinforced the other, creating a cycle that was difficult to break [1].

This gradual weakening did not happen overnight; it unfolded over generations, affecting how people lived, worked, and saw their place in society. As political power slipped away, it also changed social confidence and opportunities for future generations. Many families that once held influence found themselves struggling to adjust to new systems and expectations. Over time, these changes shaped the overall direction of the community in deep and lasting ways.



However, this period of decline also led to awareness and reform. Important movements emerged that aimed to revive education, rebuild identity, and encourage progress. Efforts such as the Aligarh Movement highlighted the importance of modern knowledge, unity, and adaptation to changing times. These reform efforts played a key role in rebuilding confidence within the Muslim community. [29] [2]

These reform efforts also marked the beginning of a new mindset. People slowly started realizing that survival in a changing world required learning new skills, embracing education, and working together. New institutions, new ideas, and new leadership began to appear, showing that even in difficult times, change was still possible. This period, although challenging, planted the seeds for future growth and awareness.

There are important lessons we can learn from this history. First, unity and strong leadership are essential for stability. Second, education plays a central role in shaping the

²⁹ Lelyveld, David. *Aligarh's First Generation*.

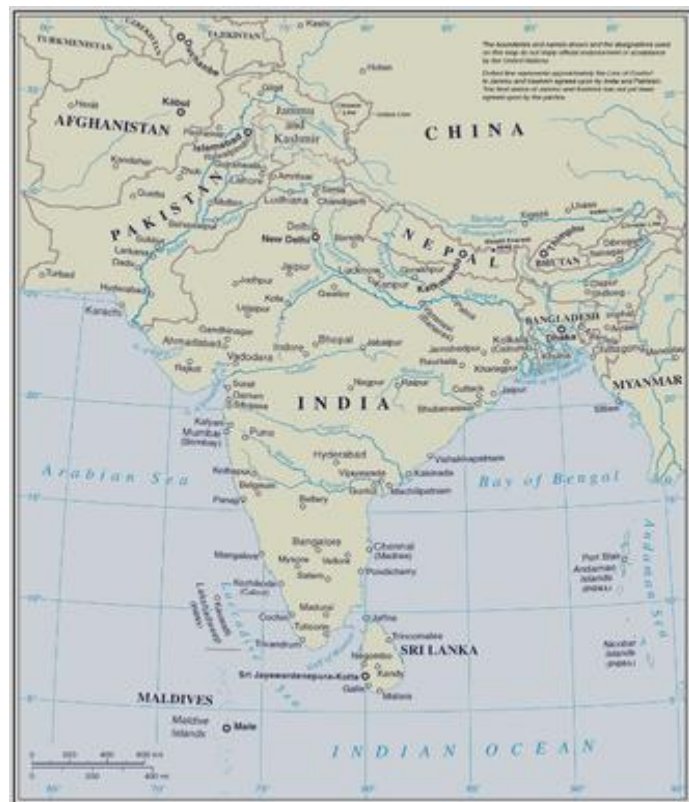
future of any community. And third, the ability to adapt to political and social change determines long-term survival and progress [1][2].

These lessons remain relevant even today. Societies that invest in education, stay united, and prepare themselves for change are better able to protect their identity and move forward with confidence. History reminds us that strength does not only come from power, but from knowledge, awareness, and the willingness to improve.

In the end, the tale of decline in south Asia is not one of loss, but one that instructs us about the future. We learn that nations crumble when they lose unity, leadership and knowledge, but flourish when they rediscover these qualities. History is not just about the past; it is about the past instructing us about the future. What we learn from the past determines who we will be in the future.

Thank you.

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